When are templates useful?

Templates are very useful for CGI programming, because adding HTML to your PHP code clutters your code and forces you to do any HTML modifications. By putting all of your HTML in seperate template files, you can let a graphic or interface designer change the look of your application without having to bug you, or let them muck around in your PHP code.

Why use FastTemplate?

Speed

FastTemplate parses with a single regular expression. It just does simple variable interpolation (i.e. there is no logic that you can add to templates - you keep the logic in the code). That's why it's has 'Fast' in it's name!

Flexibility

The API is robust and flexible, and allows you to build very complex HTML documents/ interfaces. It is also completely written in PHP and (should) work on Unix or NT. Also, it is not restricted to building HTML documents -- it could be used to build any ascii based document (postscript, XML, email - anything).

What are the steps to use FastTemplate?

The main steps are:

- define
- assign
- parse
- FastPrint

Variables

A variable is defined as:
<kbd>{([A-Z0-9_]+)}</kbd>

This means, that a variable must begin with a curly brace '{'. The second and remaining characters must be uppercase letters or digits 'A-Z0-9'. Remaining characters can include an underscore. The variable is terminated by a closing curly brace '}'.

For example, the following are valid variables:
{FOO}
{F123F}
{TOP_ OF_PAGE}

One interesting thing we have learned in years in the Web development business is that no two shops build Web applications the same way. Some have a mix of people who may be talented in certain areas, but all can do the same type of work. Others